



high school graduates. Profiling nearly a dozen cases of homegrown terror from the 9/11 attackers to the London bombers, the report describes them as being “unremarkable—they have unremarkable jobs, lead unremarkable lives and had little, if any, criminal history”. The report could well be speaking of the new terror threat that security agencies are groping with in India. Not the traditional threat of armed cross-border infiltrators but from the boys next door. Well-educated and nondescript—as much at ease in a shopping mall as they would be on Facebook. A global phenomena that has now surfaced in India.

For more than a year, members of the radical SIMI group were trained in batches of 12 in six camps that were held across Kerala, Karnataka and Gujarat. The recruits came from across the country—there were web designers from Kerala and doctors and engineers from Mangalore. Like the Batla House boys, most of the 16 youth arrested for the Ahmedabad bomb blasts did not have police records. Five were graduates or post-graduates while the rest were matriculates. Most hailed from well-to-do families and all of them, except one, were under the age of 35.

STATE OF TERROR:
Vulnerable targets (left); clearing blast debris in Malegaon



REUTERS

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

A seminal report, *The Homegrown Threat*, prepared last year by the New York Police Department's (NYPD) intelligence division bursts these three myths about homegrown terrorists: They began as radical or devout Muslims, came from economically destitute backgrounds and were poorly educated.

In reality, the terrorists were all under the age of 35, seemingly well-integrated local residents of liberal western democracies, came from reasonably well-off middle class backgrounds and were

They were motivated using Quranic speeches which played on perceived wrongs on the Muslim community—the demolition of the Babri Masjid, communal riots in Gujarat and the non-implementation of the Srikrishna Commission Report. The group which bonded at the SIMI camp prepared for vengeance killings of VIPs and further training, presumably across the border. Homegrown Islamic extremism is not a recent phenomenon—a decade ago, members of the Al Ummah carried out a series of blasts in Coimbatore, killing 58 persons. The leadership was imprisoned and the threat contained. Not so